

Remote work vs return to office on Bluesky

Do posts from the two searches differ in sentiment, vocabulary and reply structure?

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Research questions

- Sentiment:** How do sentiment categories compare between the return-to-office and remote-work search groups?
- Vocabulary:** What vocabulary characterises the English-labelled RTO and WFH search results?
- Clusters:** Do the English-labelled search results form distinct vocabulary clusters, and how are the two search groups distributed across them?
- Network:** How do accounts interact through replies around our three selected posts?

Data and methods

1,137
cleaned posts

727
English-labelled

2
searches

Data: Bluesky search via R (atrrr). “return to office” (RTO) and “remote work” (WFH), latest posts, 25 Aug to 29 Sep 2026.

Methods: Bing-lexicon sentiment with chi-squared test, word frequencies, TF-IDF with k-means, reply network (igraph).

KEY FINDING RTO-search posts were more negative than remote-work-search posts (52.0% vs 26.8% negative, $p < .001$). But the two searches retrieve different kinds of posts, so this does not show what people prefer.

1

Sentiment differs by search group

Search Group	Negative	Neutral	Positive
RTO	52.0%	11.5%	36.6%
WFH	26.8%	17.8%	55.4%

■ Negative ■ Neutral ■ Positive

Chi-squared test: $\chi^2 = 36.39$, $df = 2$, $p < .001$; Cramér’s $V = 0.26$ (small to moderate)

Search words were removed from the dictionary first. Left in, $V = 0.46$, because “work” scores as positive.

An association, not a cause.

2

Different words stand out

RTO

trump	8.4
people	7.5
policy	7.3
mandates	6.7
employees	5.4
mandate	5.4
congress	4.9

WFH

job	9.3
jobs	8.1
time	7.6
people	7.0
day	5.9
ai	5.6
disabled	5.6

RTO: policy 7.3%, mandates 6.7%, employees 5.4% of posts

WFH: job 9.3%, jobs 8.1%

Bars show % of posts containing the word (search words excluded).

3

No clear themes, mostly repeats

Cluster	Posts	RTO / WFH	What it contains
1	642	327 / 315	Mixed remainder
2	21	21 / 0	Repeated political news
3	16	0 / 16	Repeated appeals for help
4	11	0 / 11	Remote-job referral adverts
5	10	10 / 0	One auto-industry news story

642 of 700 posts (91.7%) fall in one mixed cluster. The four small clusters are repeated messages, each from one search group.

$k = 5$ was an exploratory choice; the elbow plot had no clear bend.

4

Replies centre on a few authors

Reply network across three selected conversations

62 accounts, 60 reply links, density 0.016

3 separate groups (32, 19 and 11 accounts)

Most replies go to the 3 authors of the selected posts (in-degree 29, 18 and 8)

Replies show engagement, not agreement. Only 4 accounts had any betweenness (1 each), so there is little bridging.

Conclusions

- RTO-search posts were more negative, and the association is statistically significant ($V = 0.26$).
- Part of the gap is content mix: policy and political news for RTO; job adverts, appeals and repeated messages for WFH.
- Clusters were weak and replies centred on three authors. Results describe the posts returned, not worker preferences.

Limitations

- Exact-phrase searches of the latest posts; RTO covers 25 Aug to 29 Sep, WFH only 15 to 29 Sep.
- Bluesky users are not representative; English filter uses language tags (345 posts had none).
- Dictionary sentiment misses sarcasm; the network is three hand-picked threads, two reply levels deep.